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The Learning Retention Pyramid: A Simple Guide

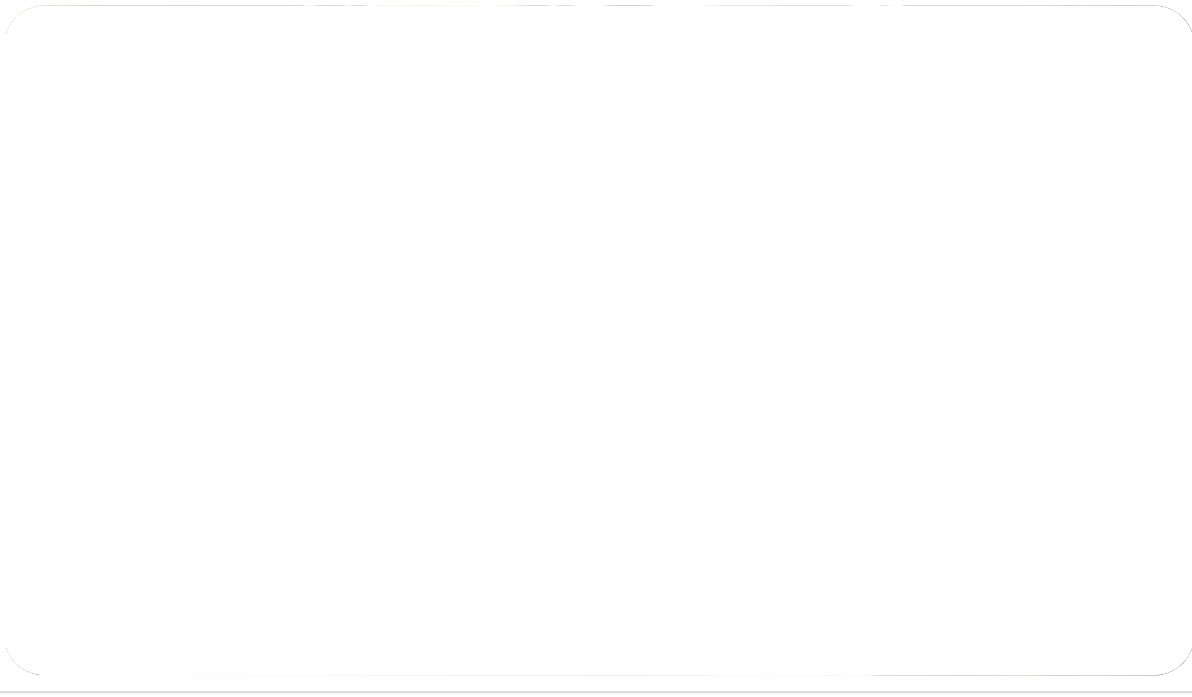
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Did you know that people only retain 5% of what is heard in a lecture?

Thinking back to some of the classes I took in high school (I'm looking at you, history), I completely believe that this may be the case.

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One factor that probably makes this statistic accurate is our short attention spans. A [study by Microsoft in 2015](#) found that **humans have an average attention span of only 8 seconds**. Keep in mind that a goldfish's attention span is 9 seconds.

So, while listening to lectures is the primary teaching method in our educational system, it's the least effective learning method. Many students have difficulty understanding new concepts after only hearing about them in a lecture-type learning setting.

If this is the case, how are we supposed to retain the information we are taught enough to recall it in the future? There's no point in spending time learning things that are almost immediately forgotten.

This is where The Learning Retention Pyramid comes into play. This pyramid illustrates various methods of learning and how effective each one is when retaining the information you're learning.

In this article, we will define the Learning Retention Pyramid, discuss each level, and discuss how you can use this information in your life.

First, let's look at what the Learning Retention Pyramid is.

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What is the Learning Retention Pyramid?

The Learning Retention Pyramid is a theoretical model that illustrates the various methods of learning and each method's respective expected percentage of retention.

This concept illustrates how well you may be able to retain information based on the various learning methods (e.g., listening to a lecture, reading a book, etc.).

Knowing about the Learning Retention Pyramid can help you better comprehend how to comprehend new information effectively.

The Learning Pyramid was originally created by [the National Training Laboratories Institute](#) in the 1960s. While some have recreated it over time, the primary information from the original model remains the same.

This model posits that teaching information to others is the most effective way to learn it yourself and the best way to ensure that the material is stored in your long-term memory.

Here is a visual depiction of this model:

According to this graphic, here is the percentage of information you will retain based on the specific actions you're taking:

5% lecture

10% reading

20% audio-visual

30% demonstration

50% discussion

75% practice doing

90% teaching others

While some have criticized the learning pyramid, its idea remains in line with research demonstrating that students can retain information more effectively if they *do* something rather than *hear* it.

Taking an active approach to learning, such as interacting with other people or physically doing something related to the material, is the best way to ensure you retain new information.

I'm sure you can recognize the relevance of this model if you think back to some instances in your life when you were learning something.

For example, think about when you were learning to drive. You probably sat through many hours of lectures regarding the rules of the road, **but were you ready to hop into the car and drive off after those classes?**

Hopefully not, and that's why driver's ed includes a "behind the wheel" component in learning this skill.

Driving with an instructor allows students to practice doing the information taught in lectures so it can be recalled more quickly when students are moving on their own.

Let's look a bit deeper at each level of this pyramid.

7 Levels of the Learning Retention Pyramid

1. Lecture

The Learning Pyramid shows that listening to a lecture is a passive way of learning and is among the most ineffective ways to learn and retain new information.

Now, this can vary a bit from person to person. Many people find it difficult to comprehend new material through lectures. However, students who are auditory learners are better at learning through this teaching method than those who are visual or kinesthetic learners.

Here is an [article that offers more information on the different learning styles](#).

However, there are some things you can do to help you retain information presented in lectures a bit better than if you sit back and listen.

You can make the most of listening to a lecture by integrating another learning style into the process, such as actively participating in any discussion and [taking notes by hand](#).

[One study conducted by researchers from UCLA and Princeton found that](#) while typing notes on a laptop may be more convenient than writing them by hand, taking the extra step of **physically writing new**

material helps students not only retain more of the information but also results in a greater understanding of the concepts being taught.

The researchers found that those who took handwritten notes were more likely to **express the information in their own words** (instead of writing it verbatim), which helped these students process and reframe the material in a way that made the most sense to them, leading to greater retention rates.

If you struggle to learn new things, this video about ten powerful mind tricks can help. You can pick up new skills quickly with just a few simple tweaks to your learning approach.

2. Reading

Reading is marginally more effective than listening to a lecture in terms of the likelihood of retaining the information.

Reading has the advantage over listening to a lecture because it provides you with reference material that you can refer to later to help you recall the material.

When you're reading, you can highlight anything that stands out to you and take additional notes. However, this model still considers reading a relatively ineffective method of learning.

While reading does add a visual piece that listening to a lecture doesn't offer, you're still passively absorbing new material.

3. Audio-Visual

The Learning Pyramid indicates that learning through audio-visual methods will typically help you retain 20% of the information offered. This method of learning may integrate learning aids such as:

Pictures

Handouts

Videos

Flip charts

Whiteboards

Slide shows

Audiotapes

Projectors

Multimedia

3D objects

...and more

Audiovisual learning may include a lecture in addition to a series of visual aids or an individual instructional video. As time has progressed and technology has evolved, innovative forms of audiovisual presentations have made it easier for students to retain new knowledge.

Like the other learning methods on the Learning Retention Pyramid, audiovisual learning is most effective when combined with other more active learning methods.

4. Demonstration

Learning by demonstration involves observing a teacher showing students how to do something by walking them through a step-by-step process. As the teacher shows how to do the task, he or she tells the students what they're doing.

The demonstration is the first method of learning on The Learning Pyramid and is considered to be “active.” Because demonstration often provides information in a more clear manner than passive study methods, it leads to a greater understanding, especially when information is vague or confusing.

Let's say you're learning how to fix a flat tire. If someone is telling you about this process but there isn't a car present to allow them to *show* you what they're talking about, **you likely won't be leaving the conversation anywhere *near* ready to start changing tires.**

You need to watch someone actually *do* it so you can get a better idea of the process they're trying to explain.

5. Discussion

Discussions offer an active, cooperative learning environment that leads to greater information retention. **They are the first form of kinesthetic learning on the Learning Pyramid.**

Discussions don't always look the same; they can take various forms. However, they always involve a collaborative, open-ended exchange of ideas to help:

- Prompt learning

- Develop new ideas

- Engage in problem-solving

- Gain a better sense of understanding

Those participating in a discussion offer a variety of points of view, respond to others' ideas, and engage in self-reflection to further their understanding or interpretation of a given subject.

A discussion between two people, a small group, or a large group with a teacher or student leader may occur. It can focus on any subjective topic or issue based on a text, something in the media, a social justice issue, a societal norm, etc.

A defining factor of a discussion is the considerable agency that participants have in determining their understanding or interpretation of the topic.

When participating in a discussion, students can decide if they agree with the credibility or validity of others' responses, which requires comprehension and reflection on the information.

6. Practice Doing

Gaining “hands-on” experience is one of the most effective learning methods. **This learning method allows you to apply what you've learned to everyday practice, which helps you recall the information in the long term.**

When you practice doing something, it makes the information more meaningful, which also leads to a deeper understanding of it and a higher retention rate.

One way technological advances have furthered opportunities to “practice doing” is through simulation. Simulated learning allows people to safely manipulate systems and then observe the impact of the change, which allows them to receive immediate intrinsic feedback.

Cognitive tools such as these offer practical hands-on training to help learners practice and gain experience that they can easily translate into real-world scenarios.

Research on brain scans of learners has shown that physically experiencing a concept helps people retain new information.

Taking this hands-on approach to mastering a topic activates the areas of the brain associated with sensory and motor skills, which was later associated with improved test performance.

Just-in-time learning makes good use of practice. The key to mastering a new skill is to focus only on the information that can be immediately applied. The video below shows an overview of just-in-time learning and the simple steps you can use to master any skill in a short amount of time.

7. Teach Others

The most

effective way to master a subject is to teach it to others. If you can teach other people about a subject correctly, it means that you understand the concepts, you have a high retention of the information, and you're able to recall it easily.

In a learning setting, this commonly takes the form of study groups or peer tutoring. It's important to remember that a critical component of learning by teaching is internalizing and comprehending the information before attempting to pass it on to others.

Learning by teaching is not effective if you rely solely on your notes when presenting the material to others.

Learning by teaching is effective for many reasons, but one main reason is that as the teacher, you can gain feedback from your students, **which can help give you a new perspective and further enhance your own learning.**

You have the opportunity to examine the information objectively and recognize any gaps in your knowledge, which may prompt you to do further research.

Your students' questions can encourage you to think about the material in different ways and require you to devise unique ways of explaining it to help others who may have a different learning style understand it.

Further, watching students solve problems lets you see your knowledge being put directly into action.

Teaching others is the most effective way to master a subject.

How to Use the Learning Retention Pyramid in Your Life

Learning in today's world looks very different than it did even 10 or 15 years ago. Now, endless online courses are available if you're looking to learn a skill or obtain a degree, **which leaves a lot of the learning process up to you.**

When you take an online course, *you* must figure out the best way to comprehend the information without having a teacher there to help answer your questions in real-time.

The Learning Retention Pyramid shows that it's safe to say that **it's not enough to listen to someone lecture you on a topic in a webinar if you're trying to learn about it.**

You have to be interested in the topic enough to want to read additional related materials, review the PowerPoint slides after the webinar, highlight your notes, and come up with actions you can take to practice the skills right away to retain the new information.

This model also shows that practicing with someone else who is learning the same material and exchanging feedback is a very effective method of storing new lessons in your long-term memory.

You have to be engaged in any learning process rather than sitting back, being a passive learner, and expecting the information to stick. Taking the initiative to engage with any material is critical to retaining it.

This points out that a significant barrier to remembering things isn't the content or your brain's capacity—it's not new or unique information versus familiar information.

Instead, your sense of interest and engagement is the most significant potential barrier to remembering something.

Final Thoughts on the Learning Pyramid

The best ways to learn anything well enough to recall it in the future are toward the bottom of the Learning Retention Pyramid.

This model illustrates that actively participating in the learning process results in a more remarkable ability to retain new information.

This doesn't mean that listening to lectures isn't also important. Even if it's a challenge to recall information from a lecture, your notes may end up being a critical component of your preparation for a discussion of the material later on or a good resource to reference if you're teaching the material to others.

In order to get the best long-term results, it's best to vary your study methods and incorporate a few of them.

Because being a lifelong learner is so important these days, it's best to make the most of your time while learning by ensuring a high retention rate of new information.

It's good to listen, but becoming engaged and gaining hands-on experience is better.

If you're looking for some inspiration to start learning, check out these blog posts:

- • [95 Education Quotes: Inspire Children, Parents, AND Teachers](#)
 - [103 Knowledge Quotes on the Importance of Always Learning](#)
 - [5 Best Speed Reading Apps to Improve Your Information Retention](#)
 - [85 Critical Thinking Questions to Carefully Examine Any Information](#)

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